intervention. Later, M.G. Ramachandran gave it mass political force. Tamil Nadu also pioneered the school egg. Under M. Karunanidhi, the state introduced one boiled egg a fortnight in 1989. J. Jayalalithaa later expanded the programme, and Tamil Nadu today is among the states where eggs are a regular part of the school menu.

A landmark 2001 Supreme Court order transformed the national programme. Responding to a PIL filed by the People's Union for Civil Liberties under the right to life, it directed states to provide cooked midday meals. The National Food Security Act, 2013, later gave children aged 6-14 a statutory right to a nutritious meal free of charge. That scheme became PM POSHAN in 2021. But the law prescribed nutrition, not its source, whether egg, milk or any specific food item. A primary-school meal must provide 450 kilocalories and 12 grams of protein. An upper-primary meal must provide 700 kilocalories and 20 grams of protein. The ingredient norms are also modest: 100 grams of grain, 20 grams of pulses, 50 grams of vegetables and five grams of oil for primary children; 150 grams of grain, 30 grams of pulses, 75 grams of vegetables and 7.5 grams of oil for older children.

The Centre's role is limited but crucial. It funds 60 per cent of the material cost in most states and 90 per cent in the Northeast and designated Himalayan states; foodgrains are supplied free. The FY27 budget allocated Rs 12,750 crore to PM POSHAN. The material cost per child per school day is Rs 6.78 for Bal Vatika to Class V and Rs 10.17 for Classes VI-VIII. Many states spend beyond this to provide eggs, milk, fruit, *chikki* or other supplements. That discretionary window is where the egg becomes vulnerable.

POLITICS OF THE PLATE

Since eggs are usually a state-funded addition, they are among the first to be sacrificed if costs rise or suppliers complain. That clear retreat was evident in Maharashtra. In 2023, the state decided to provide eggs once a week in boiled form or as egg pulao, with bananas or local fruit for non-egg-eating children. The idea was to add protein to a largely rice-based meal. An education officer with a zilla parishad recalled that children ate eggs "with relish". But the move drew opposition from religious and sectarian groups, including sections of the Jain community. In January 2025, the state withdrew funding and told school management committees to arrange public contributions if they wanted to serve eggs. A list of 12 vegetarian recipes—vegetable pulao, soyabean pulao, dal rice and the like—became the substitute.

The move generated heated debate in Maharashtra. Amjad Borkar of the Machhimar Kruti Samiti, representing fisherfolk in the Konkan, called it ironic that eggs were not being given to children on the coastline despite a majority of the population being non-vegetarian. Economist Neeraj Hatekar described eggs as an easy solution to protein malnutrition and argued that "pilot runs and randomised control trials" should precede any substitution. Shahu Patole, author of *Dalit Kitchens of Marathwada*, attributed the controversy solely to the politics of caste. Government schools, he pointed out, largely serve poor children, many from Dalit, tribal and backward communities where eggs are normal food. "These schools usually cater to the children of the poor. Then, what is the problem in giving them eggs?" he asked.

The egg naysayers seldom frame their opposition as driven by ideology. Akshay Maharaj Bhosale of the Dharmaveer Adhyatmik Sena, affiliated to Eknath Shinde's Shiv Sena, argued that children from families that do not eat non-vegetarian food may end up eating eggs in school. He suggested groundnuts, dry fruits, apples, fruits and milk instead, and raised the spectre of steroids and antibiotics in poultry. "Give students food even more nutritious than

THE PROTEIN EQUATION



One large egg packs 6-7 gram protein that costs Rs 7-8. Here's how common alternatives compare in cost—for quantity required to match nutrition



Milk
(200 ml)
Cost: Rs 12



Paneer
(40-45 g)
Cost: Rs 14-18



Soya chunks
(45-50 g cooked)
Cost: Rs 2-3



Banana
(5-6 medium size)
Cost: Rs 35-45



Peanut Chikki
(45-50 g)
Cost: Rs 10-15



Cooked Rajma
(170-180 g)
Cost: Rs 12-15